

Group Activity: Designing an Organization's Structure and Culture

This activity requires students to synthesize the various functional areas needed for a successful business and simultaneously define the organizational culture that will guide employee behavior and decision-making.

Activity Objectives

1. To list the different areas in a business organization by determining which departments are necessary for a new venture.
2. To appreciate the importance of organizational culture and how it influences operations.
3. To define and apply various dimensions of culture (e.g., values, strength, leadership style).

Part 1: Scenario Setup (15 minutes)

1. Form Groups: Divide the class into groups of 4-5 students.
2. Scenario Assignment: Each group is a leadership team tasked with launching a new product.

Task A: Establishing Functional Needs

Identify and list at least six essential functional areas that must exist in your organization to successfully launch and run the business.

- Relevant Functional Areas to choose from include:
 - Human Resource
 - Marketing
 - Sales
 - Production
 - Customer Service Support
 - Accounting and Finance
 - Distribution
 - Research and Development
 - Administrative and Management
 - Operations
 - Information Technology Support

- Purchasing
- Legal Department
- For each selected functional area, briefly state one key objective based on the source material.

Part 2: Defining Organizational Culture (20 minutes)

Now that the functional structure is established, the group must define the organization's "personality". Remember, organizational culture is a shared pattern of beliefs, assumptions, and expectations held by organization members.

Task B: Culture Blueprint

Define the following elements of your organizational culture, ensuring they are clearly ordered to guide behavior in conflict situations:

1. Core Values: Determine the essence of the organizational philosophy. List 2–3 core values (e.g., speed, quality, customer focus).
2. Cultural Strength: Decide whether your organization will have a culture where shared beliefs are strong (thick) or not widely shared (thin). Explain why this strength level is crucial for your product launch.
3. Leadership Style (Managerial Culture): Briefly describe the dominant leadership style that will define the managerial culture.
4. Cultural Symbols or Rites/Rituals: Identify one non-verbal way the culture is expressed. This could be a description of a specific rite or ritual (reflected by language and ceremonies) or a cultural symbol (a material artifact).

Part 3: Cultural Integration and Application (15 minutes)

The culture must inform members of what to believe, how to act, and make decisions.

Task C: Application Case Study

Choose two of the functional areas identified in Task A. Describe how each functional area's standard operations would be guided or modified by the culture defined in Task B.

Functional Area	Primary Function	How the Defined Culture Influences Operations
Example: Marketing	Promoting the business to generate sales and help the company grow.	If the culture emphasizes "quality over speed," the Marketing department might focus only on brand-awareness campaigns, coordinating closely with Sales, and avoid aggressive, quick-turnaround promotional campaigns.
Functional Area 1:	(State the function).	(Explain how the culture affects their duties).
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Part 4: Presentation and Reflection (5 minutes per group)

Each group will briefly present their findings, explaining:

1. Their six key functional areas.
 2. Their core values and cultural strength.
 3. How the culture (which creates social order) directs the activities of their chosen functional areas (Task C).
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Criteria Section	Assessment Focus	Maximum Points
Part 1: Functional Structure (Task A)	Listing and Defining Functional Needs	12 Points
1A. Functional Areas Identified	The group successfully identifies and lists at least six essential functional areas	6
1B. Definition Accuracy	For each of the six functional areas, the group accurately states one key objective or responsibility, drawing from the source material (e.g., Marketing: promoting the business to generate sales; Legal Department: handling customer complaints in a professional style).	6
Part 2: Culture Blueprint (Task B)	Defining Cultural Dimensions and Philosophy	15 Points
2A. Core Values	The group defines 2–3 Core Values that represent the essence of the organizational philosophy . The values are clearly ordered to guide behavior in conflict situations.	5
2B. Cultural Strength	The group decides whether the culture is strong (thick) or not widely shared (thin) , and provides a clear explanation of why that strength level is crucial for the organization's goals.	4

2C. Managerial Culture and Symbols	The group describes the dominant leadership style defining the managerial culture and identifies an appropriate cultural symbol or rite/ritual (which reflects language and ceremonies or is a material artifact).	4
2D. Coherence	The definitions reflect an understanding that organizational culture is the shared pattern of beliefs, assumptions, and expectations held by members.	2
Part 3: Cultural Integration (Task C)	Applying Culture to Functional Operations	18 Points
3A. Functional Linkage (3 points)	The primary function for the two chosen areas is correctly stated and supported by the sources (e.g., Purchasing's primary function is the procurement of raw materials).	3
3B. Influence Analysis (15 points)	The group provides a thorough description of how the defined culture (the organization's personality) guides members in how to act and make decisions . This must show how the culture modifies or directs the standard operations of the two chosen functional areas (e.g., Marketing changing its strategy based on a "quality over speed" value). <i>Note: 7.5 points per functional area analysis.</i>	15

Part 4: Presentation and Delivery	Clarity and Comprehensive Explanation	15 Points
4A. Clarity and Structure (5 points)	The group clearly presents their six functional areas, core values, and successfully explains how the culture (which creates social order) directs the activities of the chosen functional areas. The presentation is well-organized and stays within the allocated time.	15
TOTAL SCORE		60 Points